Hedwig's 9 PM Intelligence Report

Sunday, 25 October 2026

3 Things I Absolutely Should Know Today

Microsoft Research releases Orchard, an open framework for scalable agentic AI

What happened: Microsoft Research announced Orchard, a publicly available framework that includes models, training data, and evaluation methods to build autonomous AI agents capable of planning, reasoning, and acting across complex tasks.

Why you should care: The framework provides ready-to-use resources for students to experiment with building AI agents, practice prompt engineering, and explore multi-step problem solving without needing large proprietary infrastructure.

Impact: Medium

Source: Microsoft Research

Critical PHP Vulnerabilities (CVE-2026-109618 & CVE-2026-109619) Disclosed

What happened: Two remote-code-execution flaws were found in PHP's core runtime, affecting all versions serving web requests back to PHP 5; patches were released on 21 Oct 2026.

Why you should care: Most web-development projects in Indian colleges use PHP; unpatched servers can be fully compromised, leading to data loss or service disruption. Understanding the exploit vectors and applying the updates is essential for secure coding and system administration.

Impact: Medium

What to do: Apply the released patches immediately to any PHP installations used for coursework or projects.

Source: Wired

Uber HackTag - 5 Lakhs INR Prizes, Mentorship & Hiring Opportunities

What happened: Uber announced its HackTag hackathon offering prize money up to 5 Lakhs INR, mentorship from Uber engineers, and potential full-time or internship placements for winners.

Why you should care: A high-value prize and direct hiring pipeline give Diploma IT students a chance to showcase full-stack skills, network with industry professionals, and secure employment without campus placements.

Impact: Medium

Source: OpportunityHub

AI

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Impact: Medium

Source: Microsoft Research

NVIDIA launches Nemotron 3.5 Bolt E4B 4GB, a small open-weight language model for local voice agents

What happened: NVIDIA released Nemotron 3.5 Bolt E4B, a 4 GB open-weight model optimized for on-device voice assistants, game characters, and robotics, supporting multimodal (text + audio) inputs.

Why you should care: The model's modest size allows deployment on standard laptops or low-cost development boards, enabling hands-on projects in voice-controlled applications-a valuable skill set for IT diploma coursework and campus hackathons.

Impact: Medium

Source: MarkTechPost

Developer World

Google Gemini / gemini-cli

What happened: An open-source command-line tool that integrates Google's Gemini AI directly into the terminal, enabling code generation, query answering, and scripting assistance.

Why you should care: Allows Diploma IT students to experiment with AI-assisted coding, automate routine tasks, and prototype scripts without leaving their development environment-useful for projects in programming, web development, and automation.

Impact: Medium

Source: GitHub (google-gemini / gemini-cli)

Processing (open-source programming environment)

What happened: Processing, a visual-oriented programming language and IDE, has been highlighted as one of this year's most influential open-source projects for teaching code through interactive graphics and art.

Why you should care: Provides a beginner-friendly platform to learn programming fundamentals, algorithms, and UI concepts, which aligns with the curriculum of Indian IT diplomas and can be used for project work or portfolio building.

Impact: Medium

Source: GitHub Blog - This year's most influential open source projects.

Cybersecurity

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Impact: Medium

Source: Wired

Node2Shell Brotli Vulnerability (CVE-2026-111497) Evolves to HTTP2Shell

What happened: A vulnerability in the Brotli compression library used by Node2Shell was upgraded to affect broader HTTP-based applications under the name HTTP2Shell, disclosed on 22 Oct 2026.

Why you should care: Many Node.js projects and micro-services rely on Brotli for compression; the flaw can allow attackers to execute arbitrary code via crafted HTTP requests. Awareness helps you audit dependencies and apply patches in your development projects.

Impact: Medium

Source: aikido.dev

India

IndiaMEY Empanels TCS, NEC India, Kyndryl to Boost AI in Government

What happened: The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) announced the empanelment of major IT firms-including TCS, NEC India, and Kyndryl-to develop and implement artificial-intelligence solutions across government services.

Why you should care: These partnerships will create demand for AI-savvy developers and may open internship, trainee, or entry-level roles for diploma-level IT students, plus provide real-world project case studies for academic work.

Impact: Medium.

Source: Economic Times Government.

Learn

CS50: Introduction to Computer Science (Harvard) - Free Online via edX - Worth doing

What happened: Harvard's flagship introductory computer science course, CS50, is offered for free on the edX platform, providing video lectures, problem sets, and a certificate option.

Why you should care: Covers fundamental programming, algorithms, and systems concepts essential for any IT diploma curriculum; recognized internationally by employers and can strengthen your résumé without any tuition cost.

Impact: Medium

Source: OPIT

Coursera Computer Science Courses - Free Audit Options - Maybe

What happened: Coursera lists numerous computer science courses that can be audited for free, giving access to video lectures and reading materials without payment; financial aid is available for certificates.

Why you should care: Enables you to explore specific topics such as Python, data structures, or cybersecurity at your own pace, supplementing diploma coursework and building a portfolio of completed modules.

Impact: Medium

Source: Coursera

Opportunities

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Impact: Medium

Source: OpportunityHub

Juspay Hiring Challenge - Full-Time / Internship for Undergraduates

What happened: Juspay launched a hiring challenge targeted at undergraduate students, providing a coding competition that leads to full-time or internship offers for top performers.

Why you should care: Participation offers practical exposure to payment-gateway technologies, a sector with strong demand in India, and a clear pathway to employment for IT diploma holders.

Impact: Medium

Source: OpportunityHub

Events Near You

The smarter E India - Exhibition & Conference

When: March 9-11, 2027

Where: Helipad Exhibition Centre (exhibition) and Gift City Club, Gandhinagar, Gujarat (conference)

How to attend/register: Registration details are available on the event's official website; attendees can sign up online for both the exhibition and conference sessions.

Tools Worth Trying

JetBrains launches AI coding assistant "Junie" with free tier for developers

What happened: JetBrains announced Junie, an AI-driven coding agent that offers unlimited code completion and support from local AI models in its free tier, plus credit-based access to cloud-based AI tools. Higher-usage "AI Pro" and "AI Ultimate" tiers are also available.

Why you should care: The free tier lets Diploma IT students in India integrate advanced AI-assisted coding into JetBrains IDEs (e.g., IntelliJ IDEA, PyCharm) without cost, boosting productivity on assignments and projects while staying within familiar development environments.

Impact: Medium

Source: Yahoo Finance.

Tech Outside AI

OpenAI Unveils "Jalapeño" AI Inference Chip

What happened: OpenAI announced its first custom AI chip, named Jalapeño, claiming industry-leading speed and efficiency for inference workloads, positioning it as a competitor to Nvidia's dominance.

Why you should care: Understanding emerging AI hardware helps you anticipate the platforms your future projects or internships may run on, and informs curriculum choices around AI model deployment.

Impact: Medium

Source: CNBC

Nvidia's AI Chip Share Falls to 34% in China as Huawei Gains Ground

What happened: Nvidia's share of China's data-center AI chip market dropped to 34% in H1 2026, while Chinese firms like Huawei expanded their presence amid tighter U.S. export controls.

Why you should care: The shift illustrates how geopolitical factors affect hardware availability and may influence where you source components or seek employment in the Indian tech ecosystem.

Impact: Medium

Source: Mexico Business News

Nvidia and Microsoft Launch Open AI Security Alliance

What happened: Nvidia and Microsoft announced a joint Open AI Security Alliance aimed at fostering secure and open AI development, positioning themselves as leaders in AI safety standards.

Why you should care: Understanding industry-driven security frameworks is essential for IT students building AI-enabled applications, especially when working with Microsoft Azure and Nvidia GPUs in Indian tech projects.

Impact: Medium

Source: The Verge

Pentagon Expands Classified AI Partnerships to Eight Major Tech Firms

What happened: The U.S. Department of Defense signed classified AI agreements with eight leading companies-including Nvidia, Microsoft, Google, Amazon Web Services, OpenAI, SpaceX, Oracle, and Reflection-excluding Anthropic.

Why you should care: The deals highlight the strategic importance of enterprise-grade AI platforms and cloud services; familiarity with these vendors' tools (e.g., Azure AI, Nvidia CUDA, Google Cloud AI) will enhance employability and project readiness for Indian IT graduates.

Impact: Medium

Source: DefenseScoop

My Action for Tomorrow

Register for the Uber HackTag hackathon and begin assembling a project team to develop a full-stack prototype you can submit.

If You Only Remember 3 Things

- Orchard offers a ready-made AI agent framework for hands-on experimentation.
- Patch PHP immediately to mitigate critical remote-code-execution bugs.
- Uber HackTag provides a high-value competition and direct hiring path for diploma students.